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Seen, Not Sure

A School Messaging App's Read Receipt Against What Guardians Actually Recall

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The problem

A primary-school messaging app logs a "seen by" timestamp the moment a guardian opens a notice. Schools treat the tick as proof the message landed. Does opening a notice mean anything in it was understood?

What we set out to test

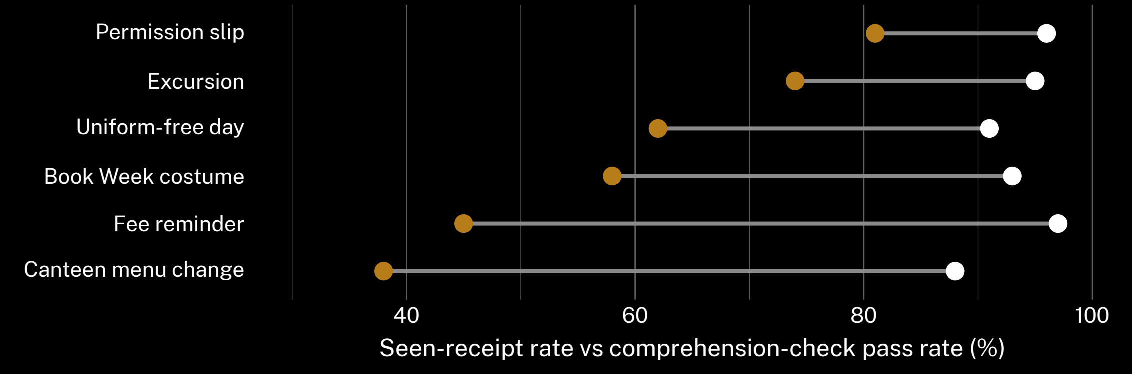
- Cross-reference each notice's seen-receipt log against guardians' recall of its content
- Compare the seen rate and the comprehension rate across notice types
- Test whether a deadline or a fee attached to a notice widens the gap

Study design

- n = 618 guardian-notice pairs · 9 primary schools · 1 messaging app
- Comprehension checked by a single follow-up question at pickup, within 48 hours of the seen timestamp
- Notice type, deadline presence, and days-to-follow-up held as covariates

Findings

The seen-receipt rate holds high and stable across notice types (88-97%); the comprehension rate does not track it. Guardians recorded as having seen a notice answer no more accurately, on average, than those the app logged as never opening it.



Seen-receipt rate holds within a nine-point band across notice types (88-97%, March-June 2026); comprehension trails by 15 points on permission slips and by 50 on canteen menu changes.

What it means

A guardian-level correlation between seen-status and comprehension-check accuracy sits at r = 0.14 (n = 618) — indistinguishable in strength from guessing which notices were logged as unopened. The receipt tracks whether a screen was tapped, not whether anything on it survived the tap.
Next: extend the comprehension check to a one-week recall window, to see whether the gap widens or simply relocates.

Selected references

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Comprehension checks administered verbally at pickup; no phone screens inspected. Guardian responses de-identified at collection.

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